Had it not been for Sheikh Abdullah, it is probable that Article 370 would have been much more clearly defined. It would have been quite possible to arrange, subject to popular ratification, that the state of Jammu and Kashmir would eventually have a constitution just like that of the other Indian states of the same class. This was the previously mentioned ‘Mysore model’.

Meanwhile, in July 1950, a restless Abdullah, who found Pakistani intransigence was delaying the adoption of the UN suggested plebiscite, decided to whet the appetite of his popular base in the state by sending a proclamation to the Regent, Yuvaraja Karan Singh, requesting his signature. This proclamation announced the abolition of *Jagirdari* (the feudal land grant system) and of landlordism, both without offering any compensation. These populist measures were ideologically leftist and also communal in that they would adversely affect the non-Muslim population of the state. The Regent demurred and referred the matter to the Government of India. This incensed Abdullah, who took to the streets and announced measures that were patently illegal without the consent and signature of the Regent. At the same time, Abdullah began articulating his vision of independence for the state and its freedom from the yoke of the Maharaja, who was legally still the ruler. This culminated in the move to convene a constituent assembly for the state as part of a broader political strategy to make the question of plebiscite redundant.

When the provisions for elections for a constituent assembly for Jammu and Kashmir were formally announced by the Regent on 30 April 1951, it was clear that the assembly would concern itself with broader issues than merely devising a constitution for the state. It would also decide, once and for all, the future of the Dogra dynasty and would determine whether landowners and holders of land rights would (or, as Sheikh Abdullah wished, would not) be compensated for their losses under the land reform measures that had already been put to effect.

In August 1951, elections to the proposed Jammu and Kashmir Constituent Assembly had been conducted under a proclamation issued by the Regent.[16] The only effective opposition group, the Praja Parishad in